

CYBERSECURITY FORENSIC INCIDENT REPORT

Analyst:	Dr. Emily Richardson
Organization:	NCSC UK
Malware:	APT29 (Cozy Bear)
Threat Level:	HIGH
File Hash:	098f6bcd4621d373cade4e832627b4f6
Location:	London

INCIDENT DESCRIPTION:

On 22nd January 2025 at 14:23 GMT, the Security Operations Center detected suspicious network traffic originating from a workstation at a government contractor facility in Central London. The initial vector of compromise was identified as a spear-phishing email containing a weaponized Microsoft Office document with embedded macros. The document, masquerading as a legitimate procurement request, exploited CVE-2023-38831 vulnerability in WinRAR.

Upon execution, the malware established persistence through scheduled tasks and registry modifications (HKLM\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Run). The payload communicated with C2 infrastructure using encrypted HTTPS traffic to domain "update-service-ms[.]com" resolving to IP address 194.165.16.88. Traffic analysis revealed data exfiltration attempts totaling approximately 3.7GB, primarily targeting strategic planning documents and internal communications.

The threat actor demonstrated sophisticated TTPs (Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures) consistent with APT29 attribution, including use of Cobalt Strike beacons for command execution and credential dumping via Mimikatz. Lateral movement was observed across 7 network segments using Pass-the-Hash techniques. Immediate containment measures have been implemented, including network segmentation and deployment of custom YARA rules for threat hunting across the enterprise environment.